

What to look for when you go MFD-shopping

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First Things First

Remember: if any component of the MFD fails, you're going to have to send the entire unit for repair. Check the warranty and repair policies.

Printing

MFDs are available in both the laser and inkjet varieties. The laser option is only available in monochrome. So, if you will primarily use the MFD as a printer, with the fax and scanner as secondary peripherals, opt for an MFD with a laser printer sub-unit.

Copying

When copying documents, speed is important, and the copying quality should be acceptable. Copying a document involves both the scanner and the printing unit, which makes it important that they both operate fast enough to make for fast copying. Also, make sure that the MFD can copy without involving a PC.

If you're buying a colour inkjet MFD, make sure it can scan in either 24-bit or 30-bit colour. Other copying features should include a range of reduction and enlargement settings, the ability to print 50 to 100 copies at a time, and one-touch single copies.

Faxing

Most mid-end and high-end MFDs offer fax capabilities. Opt for one that offers a separate telephone handset. Also check the capacity of the ADF (Automatic Document Feeder), the memory presets it offers, and whether it offers speed-dial. Can it broadcast

to different locations successively, or does it need someone to manually do the task? Is there a buffer where incoming faxes can be stored until paper is fed back into the tray? Also, on high-end MFDs, check if the unit supports features such as caller ID and voice mail.

Resolutions

You need to look at both the printing and scanning resolutions. An MFD scanner unit isn't meant to replace a high end scanner, so a scanning resolution of 200 dpi should do fine. A printing resolution of 600 x 600 is preferred, though 720 x 360 should suffice.

Don't fall for scanning resolutions such as 1,200 x 1,200 dpi, which are mostly interpolated, meaning that the image size is adjusted in software. This results in disk space wastage and slows down scanning.

Ink/toner configuration

If you're opting for a laser printing sub-unit, check the rated life of the toner cartridge, since this varies. Opt for an MFD that has separate tri-colour cartridge, and a separate black one. It would be great if the MFD lets you replace the colour cartridge with a black cartridge, as and when required.

Speed

Check rated printing speed for black documents in pages per minute (ppm) since it will affect copying as well as the receiving of incoming faxes. Since black-ink documents will be more frequently printed than colour documents. Scanning rates may or may not be available, but if the printing speed is fast enough, it's safe to assume that the scanner will function at a respectable speed. Always keep in mind that colour printing will be slower than black printing. Also, the copying speed should be almost equal to the printing speed.



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